

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Illinois Dems push last-minute goals

As Biden’s term comes to end, priorities include pardons, trade policy, immigration

By Daniel C. Vock
Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON — One month before President Joe Biden cedes the White House to Republican President-elect Donald Trump, Biden’s administration and the Democratic majority in Illinois’ congressional delegation are scrambling to check off final items on their to-do lists.

The top priorities for those representing the Chicago area on Capitol Hill include pardons for nonviolent offenders, including former U.S. Rep. Jesse Jackson Jr., cracking down on Chinese trade policies and solidifying legal protections for immigrants who might otherwise get caught up in mass deportations promised by Trump.

But the congressional timeline

is more compressed than usual as Congress is scheduled to wrap up business by Thursday and lawmakers must agree on a spending plan to keep the federal government open before the current fiscal plan runs out at the end of the work week.

One possible upside to the tight schedule, however, is that the process of reaching a compromise to avert a government shut-down can open up the window for deal-making. That’s especially true this year in the U.S. House as Republicans have a slim major-

ity but several GOP lawmakers routinely vote against such spending deals, meaning the GOP needs some Democratic votes to keep the federal government’s lights on.

“In the lame duck (session), you’re shooting with live ammunition and very often you can make historic differences,” said U.S. Rep. Bill Foster, a Democrat who represents the far west suburbs.

As Congress rushes toward the doors, U.S. Rep. Raja Krishnamoorthi hopes the Democratic-controlled Senate will pass legislation he sponsored that would set up a

new unit in the Justice Department to prosecute trade-related crimes.

The northwest suburban Democrat, who is a vocal critic of the Communist-controlled Chinese government, said his bill would let prosecutors crack down on China and other countries that try to illegally subsidize exports, avoid U.S. tariffs by shipping goods through other countries, or commit fraud.

Those unfair trade practices have harmed businesses in his

Turn to Goals, Page 4

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL



Former state Rep. Edward Acevedo leaves the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse after testifying in Chicago on Tuesday. **TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Acevedo challenged on stand as government’s case winds down

Ex-state representative’s testimony likely to be framed by defense as unreliable

By Jason Meisner
and Megan Crepeau
Chicago Tribune

Former state Rep. Edward Acevedo’s testimony in the Michael Madigan corruption trial on Tuesday was testy from the moment a prosecutor said “Good morning.”

“Good morning. Can you hear me?” Assistant U.S. Attorney Amarjeet Bhachu asked Acevedo, a former Chicago police officer and one of Madigan’s floor leaders in the House.

“Are you talking to me?” Acevedo asked.

“I am,” Bhachu shot back. “Did

you bring your glasses today, sir?”

Acevedo said he did, and held them up for Bhachu to see.

“Congratulations,” Bhachu said.

By reminding Acevedo of his failure to bring his glasses to court the day before — which drew the ire of the judge — Bhachu began his spiky and rapid-fire questioning of a complicated witness as the trial inched closer to an end.

Prosecutors had in fact been expected to rest their case in chief Tuesday afternoon, after Acevedo left the stand and they presented a handful of remaining witnesses and wiretaps.

Instead, U.S. District Judge

John Robert Blakey sent jurors home for the day at about 2:30 p.m., telling them only that he had “some legal matters to attend to.” Bhachu later told the judge they had some “homework to do,” but the attorneys said nothing in court about the reason for the sudden change of plans.

The focus lingered on Acevedo for much of Tuesday, though he was on the stand relatively briefly, testifying for only an hour altogether between Monday afternoon and Tuesday morning.

It’s unclear how much his testimony helped the prosecution’s case, if at all. Acevedo has been diagnosed with dementia

and a brain tumor, and his testimony, which was scattershot at best, is sure to be framed by the defense as unreliable.

Other witnesses were called Tuesday to contradict some of Acevedo’s claims or confirm that he had previously told authorities something different than what he said on the stand.

In the end, prosecutors were able to strengthen allegations that Acevedo was paid a lot of money over the years for doing little or no work — and show jurors he committed tax fraud by hiding income from the IRS.

Turn to Trial, Page 10

Kyiv claims slaying of Russian general

Ukraine says officer responsible for use of banned weapons

By Anton Troianovski
and Constant Méheut
The New York Times

A general in charge of the Russian military’s nuclear and chemical weapons protection forces was killed by a bomb on a Moscow street Tuesday, in one of the most brazen assassinations since Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine nearly three years ago.

The general, Igor Kirillov, 54, died along with an aide after an explosive device planted in a scooter was detonated Tuesday morning near the entryway to a residential building, Russia’s Investigative Committee, a law enforcement agency, said in a statement.

An official with Ukraine’s security service, known as the SBU, said that Ukraine was responsible for the killing. The official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss a sensitive intelligence operation, confirmed the details of the assassination given by Russia.

The SBU considered Kirillov a legitimate target, the official said.

A day before the general’s killing, Ukraine had accused him of criminal activity, saying he was responsible for the “massive use of banned chemical weapons” in Ukraine. The security service said Russian troops had dropped ammunition with toxic compounds onto Ukrainian positions in efforts to force Ukrainian soldiers out of their trenches.

According to the Russian mili-

Turn to General, Page 5

INSIDE

‘Somebody is going to blow a gasket soon’

With losses mounting for the Bears, and evidence firing coach and offensive coordinator didn’t help, frustration grows. **Chicago Sports**

Savor the flavor of the holiday season

Enjoy the miracle of a stress-free Christmas and Hanukkah with offers and specials from Chicago restaurants. **Food & Health**

TODAY’S WEATHER

High **36**
Low **23**



Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 18

\$4.00 city and suburbs
and elsewhere
177th year No. 353
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Grubhub to pay \$25M, end misleading practices

Food delivery service settles with FTC, state attorney general

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

Grubhub has agreed to pay \$25 million and put an end to practices that included misleading customers over the costs of using the food delivery service and listing restaurants without their consent under a proposed settlement with the Federal Trade Commission and Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul’s office, the agencies said Tuesday.

Most of the money from the \$25 million settlement with the Chicago-based company is to be returned to customers, drivers and affected businesses nationally, FTC Midwest Region Director Jason Adler said.

The settlement is “the

Turn to GrubHub, Page 2



Federal Trade Commission Chair Lina M. Khan smiles after speaking Tuesday at a Chicago news conference where the FTC announced action against Grubhub. Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul, right, joined her. **TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**